Food Remedy API

Food Allergen Labelling in Australia – RE003

Prepared for: Food Remedy API Team

Date: 2 August 2025

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Introduction

Food allergies are an increasing concern in many countries, including Australia. For people who are sensitive to certain foods, even tiny amounts of allergens can lead to serious health issues. In some cases, these reactions can be life-threatening. Therefore, food labels must be clear, accurate, and easy to understand. This helps consumers know what they are eating and avoid foods that could cause harm.

Australia has established a specific set of rules for food allergen labelling. These rules are part of the Food Standards Code, overseen by Food Standards Australia New Zealand (FSANZ). Over time, FSANZ has updated its regulations to improve how allergens are listed on packaging. The most significant change occurred in 2021 with the introduction of the Plain English Allergen Labelling (PEAL) system. This new system aims to make allergen labels simpler for everyone to read and understand.

This report describes how food allergen labelling functions in Australia. It details the PEAL system, the list of allergens that must be declared, and the responsibilities of food businesses. It also discusses the voluntary labelling system for potential allergen traces, known as Precautionary Allergen Labelling (PAL). The report further explains how allergen information should be provided for unpackaged food. Finally, it offers suggestions on how this system could be integrated into a digital app like Food Remedy.

Allergen Labelling Framework in Australia

Food allergen labelling in Australia is governed by the Australia New Zealand Food Standards Code. This legal document sets the rules that all food businesses must follow. These rules apply to all packaged food sold in Australia, including both local and imported products. There are three main requirements for allergen labelling: Mandatory Allergen Declarations, Processing Aids and Additives, and Plain English Allergen Labelling (PEAL).

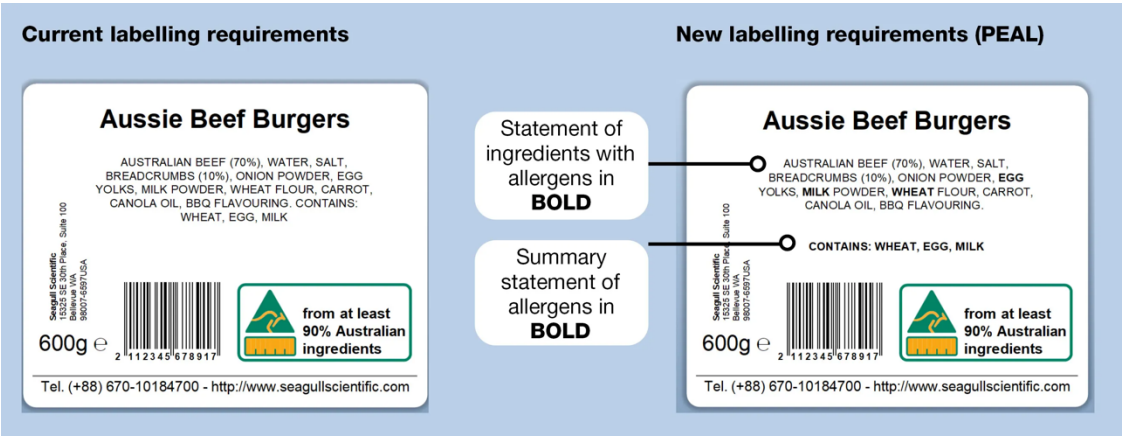
1. **Mandatory Allergen Declarations:** Eleven allergens must be declared if they are used in a food product. These include peanuts, tree nuts, milk, eggs, sesame, soy, wheat, fish, crustacea, molluscs, and lupin. If any of these are present as ingredients, food businesses are required to list them on the label.
2. **Processing Aids and Additives:** Allergens must be declared even when they are used as processing aids or food additives. For example, if milk is used to help process a food product, it still needs to be listed.
3. **Plain English Allergen Labelling (PEAL):** Introduced in 2021, PEAL requires allergen information to be presented in plain, easy-to-understand language. For instance, "milk" should be used instead of chemical terms like "casein." Allergens must also be written in bold and included in a separate "Contains" statement.

Food businesses were given a transition period of three years to comply with the PEAL rules. Products packaged after February 25, 2024, must follow the new regulations, while products made before this date can still be sold until February 2026. During this period, both old and new formats may appear on supermarket shelves.

Plain English Allergen Labelling (PEAL)

The PEAL system was created to fix problems with the way allergens were labelled in the past. Before PEAL, many food labels used technical or unclear terms. This made it hard for people with allergies to know what they could safely eat. For example, someone with a milk allergy might not recognise the word "lactoglobulin" as a milk product. PEAL solves this by using simple and consistent wording.
The PEAL system has three main features:

- **Simple Terms**: The names of allergens must be written clearly. Instead of "tree nuts," the label must say exactly which nut is used, like "cashew" or "almond."
- **Bold Font**: Allergen names must appear in bold in the ingredient list. This makes them easy to find.
- **Summary Statement**: A separate line starting with "Contains" must be placed near the ingredient list. This statement repeats the allergen names for quick reference.



Precautionary Allergen Labelling (PAL)

Sometimes, allergens are not ingredients but might be present in a food product due to shared equipment or handling. These are known as “traces” or “cross-contact.” In Australia, food businesses are not required to label for these risks, but many choose to do so. This is called Precautionary Allergen Labelling (PAL).

Allergen Labelling for Unpackaged Food

Food sold without packaging, such as meals from restaurants or food courts, must still follow allergen rules. While these products do not have a printed label, the business must still provide allergen information.

This information can be given verbally or in writing. Staff must be trained to answer questions correctly and must know where to find allergen information. If a mistake is made and a customer has an allergic reaction, the business could face legal action.

Written signs, menus with allergen keys, or printed allergen guides can help reduce risk. Some food outlets choose to display signs telling customers to ask staff about allergens. While this is allowed, it does not remove the business’s responsibility to give accurate information.

Conclusion

Australia’s allergen labelling system is designed to protect consumers and help them make informed food choices. The PEAL system has made labels easier to read and more consistent. Mandatory labelling rules ensure that allergens are declared in all forms, including additives and processing aids. The voluntary PAL system, when used properly, adds another layer of safety.

Food businesses must take their responsibilities seriously. Mistakes in allergen labelling can lead to serious health outcomes, legal penalties, and loss of customer trust. At the same time, consumers also benefit from learning how to read labels and understanding the risks of cross-contact.
As food systems become more complex, clear allergen labelling will remain a key part of public health. The Australian model offers useful lessons for other countries and for digital tools such as the Food Remedy API, which aim to make allergen information more accessible.

7. References

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